

TWO CAMPS ON THE BRINK

At several points throughout the Cold War, tensions almost reached boiling point, but direct conflict or “hot” war between the US and the Soviet Union was avoided.

1961 The building of the **Berlin Wall** is ordered by Walter Ulbricht, leader of East Germany, to stop the flow of refugees across the border from East to West Berlin.

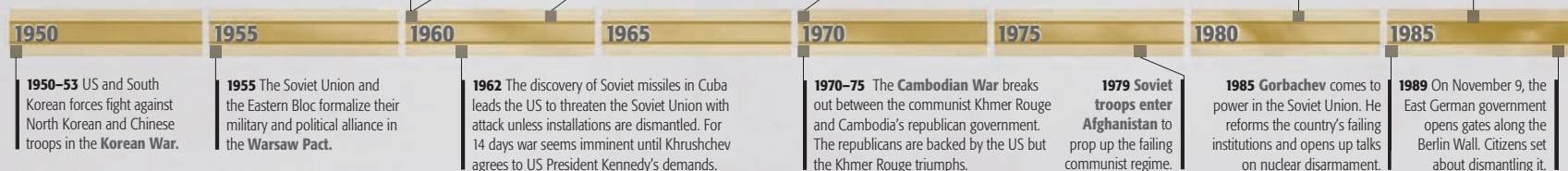
1961 The US funds and organizes Cuban exiles in a bungled attempt to invade Cuba at the **Bay of Pigs** and depose the communist leader Fidel Castro.

1964–73 The US enters the **Vietnam War** to back the South Vietnamese army against North Vietnamese communists, the Vietcong. By the time a ceasefire is signed, 58,000 US lives and many more Vietnamese are lost.

1970 The **Nuclear Non-proliferation Treaty**, signed by the US and the Soviet Union to build an effective system of controls to prevent the spread of nuclear weapons, comes into effect.

1983 US President Reagan announces the **Star Wars** program, which gives the US space-based protection against attack from the Soviet Union, which he calls the **Evil Empire**.

1987 The **Intermediate-Range Nuclear Forces Treaty** is signed by presidents Reagan and Gorbachev, ending the arms race.



After World War II, Germany was divided into four zones, each separately administrated by the US, France, Britain, and the Soviet Union. The German capital, Berlin, was situated deep in the Soviet zone and was split into four allied sectors. In 1948 the Western allies planned a separate West German state, uniting the US, French, and British zones. The Soviets tried to stop this by cutting off land routes into the Western sectors of Berlin, leaving only air access. For the next year, as diplomatic battles raged, the Berlin Airlift (see below) brought supplies to besieged Berliners. By 1949 division of Germany appeared to be inevitable. The German Democratic Republic was created in East Germany and the

Federal Republic of Germany in the west. Berlin remained a divided city. In 1961 the barbed wire partitions were replaced by the Berlin Wall (see p.426).

The Cold War heats up

The superpowers' possession of weapons of mass destruction generated much of the fear and paranoia that characterizes the Cold War era. Initially the US was the only nation in possession of nuclear weapons, but once the Soviets tested their own nuclear



Cuban missile crisis

Nuclear weapons were mobilized in Havana (above) as the US and the Soviet Union threatened each other with nuclear attack in an escalating argument over the building of Soviet nuclear installations in Cuba.

bomb in August 1949, any future conflict carried the threat of global destruction. In 1953 the Soviet leader, Nikita Khrushchev, promoted a policy of “peaceful coexistence” with the West, and periodic attempts were made on both sides to create a thaw in relations. However, there were many flash points that reignited tensions

and suspicions, bringing the world to the brink of catastrophe. In 1962, crisis was narrowly averted after a tense standoff when Soviet missile installations were discovered in communist Cuba. The superpowers continued to stockpile nuclear arms, reasoning that nuclear war

could only be prevented if each side had an equal capacity to destroy the other. A range of arms agreements were negotiated during the Cold War, but disarmament was not considered to be a possibility.

DECISIVE MOMENT

SIGNING THE NATO TREATY

On April 4, 1949 the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) was founded by the leaders of the United States, Canada, Britain, France, and several other European countries. NATO was, first and foremost, a military alliance that guaranteed assistance between member states and, crucially, allowed the US to maintain military bases in Europe. In 1953, Greece and Turkey entered NATO but a Soviet request for membership was rejected.



AFTER

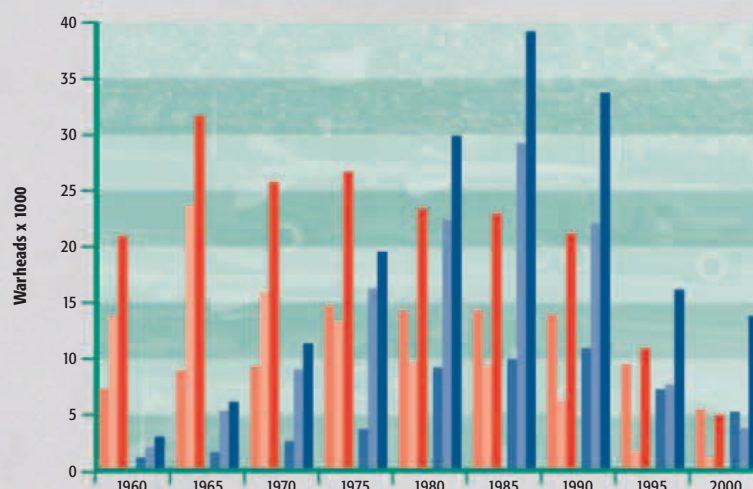
The reforming political leader Mikhail Gorbachev unintentionally set off a chain of events that would break up the Soviet Union.

COLLAPSE OF COMMUNISM

In 1985 **Gorbachev** started to campaign for economic and political reforms known as *glasnost* and *perestroika* **446–47**. Two years later he became president and modernized the Soviet system, encouraging the creation of a private sector and openness with the West. He aimed to keep a one-party political system, but his social reforms sparked a chain reaction that led to the collapse of the Communist Party as Russians demanded choice in their leaders.

DISSOLUTION OF THE SOVIET UNION

In the Baltic States, Kazakhstan, and other parts of the Soviet Union, nationalists rose up to demand independence from Moscow. Gorbachev tried to hold the Soviet Union together, imposing sanctions and sending troops into Georgia and Azerbaijan. In 1990 **Boris Yeltsin** resigned from the Communist Party and began to campaign for its dissolution. In 1991 he emerged as the new Russian leader. He banned the Communist Party and dissolved the Soviet Union.



The arms race

The race to stockpile arms represents the superpowers' Cold War conflict in graphic terms. Each side rapidly developed the capacity to destroy the world many times over, but both continued to manufacture weapons at huge expense, competing to develop missiles that were ever more efficient.

MISSILE STOCKS

US			RUSSIA		
■	Strategic		■	Strategic	
■	Tactical		■	Tactical	
■	Stockpile		■	Stockpile	